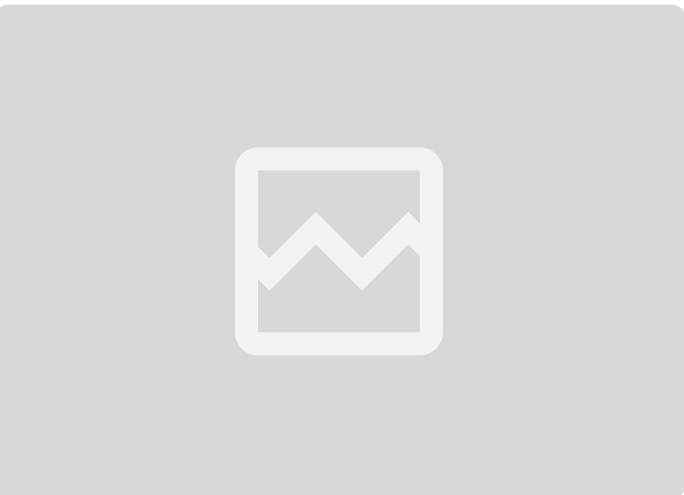




Exploratory User Research

Prepare a semi-structured interview guide

Preparing a semi-structured interview guide helps ensure that data collection is systematic while still allowing flexibility to explore unexpected insights that emerge during the conversation.

[Learn more in the UX/UI Hub](#)

Why does it matter in this phase?

In exploratory user research, the goal is not to validate predefined assumptions, but to **understand users’ experiences, needs, and perspectives in depth**. A semi-structured interview guide provides a balance between consistency and openness: it ensures that **key topics are covered** across participants, while allowing the researcher to **adapt questions based on participants’ responses and context**.

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Step by step guidance

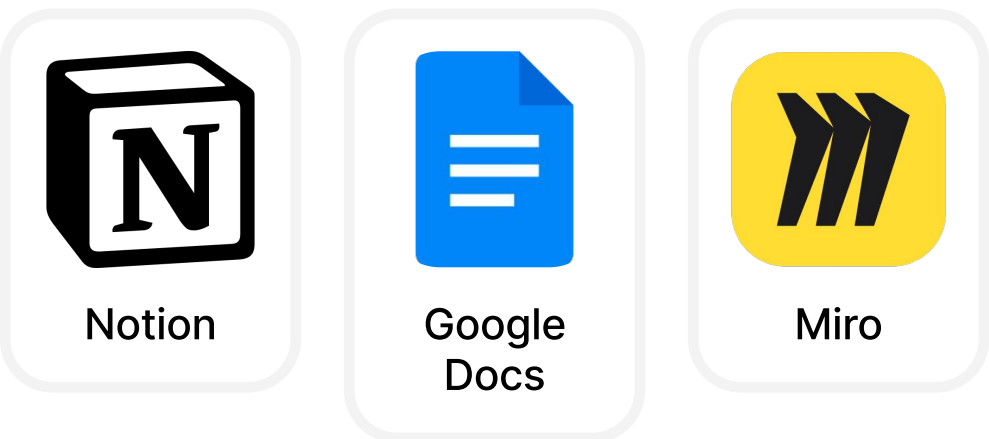
- ☐ **Define the research objectives**
Clarify what you aim to learn from the interviews and how this relates to your broader research questions. Objectives should focus on understanding users’ needs, motivations, behaviors, or challenges rather than evaluating solutions.
- ☐ **Identify key themes and topics**
Determine the main topics that need to be covered during the interview (e.g. current practices, pain points, decision-making processes, contextual constraints). These themes will structure the interview guide.
- ☐ **Formulate open-ended questions**
Write open-ended questions that encourage participants to describe experiences in their own words. Avoid leading questions or terminology that presupposes specific answers.
- ☐ **Define follow-up and probing questions**
Prepare optional probes that can be used to deepen understanding, clarify responses, or explore emerging themes without disrupting the conversational flow.
- ☐ **Decide on interview structure**
Organize questions in a logical sequence, typically moving from general topics to more specific ones. Include a short introduction and closing section to contextualize the interview and allow participants to add final remarks.
- ☐ **Pilot the interview guide**
Test the guide internally or with a small number of participants to assess clarity, timing, and relevance. Use feedback to refine question wording or structure.
- ☐ **Document rationale and assumptions**
Briefly document why specific topics and questions were included, and note any assumptions underlying the interview design. This supports transparency and later academic justification.

Outputs to produce

⚠️ Don't forget to upload them in the documentation section!

- ☐ **Interview guide document**
A structured document outlining interview sections, questions, and optional probes.
- ☐ **Research objectives statement**
A short description linking interview questions to the overall research goals.
- ☐ **Pilot feedback notes**
Notes documenting insights and adjustments made after testing the interview guide.

Recommended tools



Assignee

NG

Naomi García
Collaborator